

“Freedom is difficult to experience when you’re worried about next month’s bills,” he says. “Before I stepped away from full-time work, I built a financial runway that could sustain my lifestyle for at least a year. That cushion didn’t just provide money; it removed fear.”

For Vengurlekar, career transitions are often framed incorrectly. “People often think career transitions are about courage. In reality, they’re about preparation. If you’re considering leaving a stable job, you need a corpus that can cover at least 12 to 24 months of expenses, including health emergencies and unexpected costs.”

Yet the decision was never about withdrawing from work. But the hardest part of leaving corporate life, he argues, is rarely financial. “It’s an emotional challenge. Earlier in life, I tried similar experiments and failed because I wasn’t emotionally ready.” He also believes early-retirement conversations often ignore the importance of community.

“If you’re planning a major life transition, don’t do it alone... You need a tribe, people who understand your choices, challenge you when needed and support you when things get difficult.”

Vengurlekar believes the debate around early retirement is asking the wrong question. “The goal isn’t to stop working at 40. The goal is to stop doing work that disconnects you from yourself.”

RETIRING FROM STRESS

If Vengurlekar represents professionals redesigning life after corporate careers, global wellness leader Saurabh Bothra questions whether retirement is even the right goal.

An IIT-BHU graduate who stepped away from a conventional engineering path to build



“Personal inflation can be higher because inflation in services, travel, healthcare, domestic help, education, lifestyle upgrades and discretionary spending has historically been higher”

MIHIR VORA
Chief Investment Officer,
Trust Mutual Fund



“The journey from the Great Resignation, through mass lay-offs, to quiet quitting reflects a workforce that has been operating under sustained pressure for years”

MANSEE SINGHAL
Careers Leader India,
Mercer

Habuild—one of India’s largest wellness communities—Bothra believes the fascination with early retirement often misses the real issue.

For Bothra, the problem is not work itself, but the relationship people have with it.

“If your mind is peaceful, you can continue working, contributing and creating for a very long time. Mental peace doesn’t come from changing your job title. It comes from learning how to manage your mind.”

Yet, contentment should not be mistaken for complacency, he says.

“Being content doesn’t mean becoming lazy. It means being disciplined enough to know what

truly matters and not constantly chasing more. Contentment is not the absence of ambition. It is freedom from unnecessary craving.”

Even as he advocates a simpler life, Bothra stresses that any decision to slow down must be supported by financial preparedness. “Freedom without financial stability can quickly become stress.”

For him, the future lies somewhere between burnout and complete retirement.

And that may be the real story behind India’s growing early-retirement movement. For many professionals, the aspiration is not to stop working altogether, but to build a life where work no longer comes at the cost of health, freedom and peace of mind. **BT**